

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost 6

Another Kind of Freedom ~ Justice, Mercy, Humility
12 July 2026



"Justice, Mercy, Humility"
The Trinity of Wisdom

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Guest Organist*

Fanfare, Kenneth Leighton (1929-1988)
A Song of Sunshine, Alfred Hollins (1865-1942)
Aria, Paul Manz (1919-2009)
All Praise to Thee, My God, This Night, arr. Paul Manz
Fiesta, Emma Lou Diemer (1927-2024)
Roulade, Seth Bingham (1882-1972)
Processional, William Mathias (1934-1992)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Michael Schiefelbein & Rev. Fregin

So much has been hidden:
To protect narratives and people.
To disempower.
To confuse.

Unsatisfied with stories that get us by
but never get us free,
may we be people who search beyond,
who listen beneath,
who feel through and through.

Though we know only in part,
we do not grow weary in faith.
Though the chaos of injustice shrouds our view,
with each new learning and unlearning
the partial fades away.
The histories
and complicities
and losses
and power
of our entangled lives
cry out for understanding.

With courage, we open ourselves to truth.
With humility, we endeavor to be transformed.
With hope, we hold on to each other.

May Love lead us in the sacred work of unveiling.

May all that shrouds justice be uncovered
and the ways of healing mercy revealed.

[Rev. M Jade Kaiser, *enfleshed*]

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

In the Midst of New Dimensions

NEW DIMENSIONS

In the midst of new dimensions, in the face of changing ways.
Who will lead the pilgrim peoples wandering in their separate ways?
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

Through the flood of hurting people, warring factions and despair,
Who will lift the olive branches? Who will light the flame of care?
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

As we stand a world divided by our own self seeking schemes,
Grant that we, your global village, might envision wider dreams.
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

-Words and Music by Julian Rush (1985)

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Mysterious and Powerful Love, shake our old ways!
Make vivid a new path.
Radicalize our spirits towards compassion.
Alchemize our anger into hope and change.
What joy, what delight, is to be found in co-creating beauty with you, O God,
and with each other.
What wonder is to be found in open-hearted living.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Amen and amen.

***Introit**

"Arise, Shine"
Laude

JAEBON HWANG

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Schiefelbein

*Creator of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.*

*May your dreams of justice, love, compassion, and
connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys and
liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power-over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and our strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[enfleshed/adpt/lvf]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

As we continue through this summer season, let us hold each other carefully
as we journey...

In caring for one another,
may we be untiring
In challenging one another,
may we be respectful,
In sheltering one another,
may we be strong,
In holding one another,
may we be tender.

In the expectations we have of one another,
may we be realistic.
In the songs we sing together,
may we seek harmony.
And in loving one another,
may we be all these things and more.

As we seek to hold faith together, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from Micah 6.8*

Rev. Schiefelbein

God has shown you, O mortals, what is good. And what does God require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God.

For this witness of our ancestors...

Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of justice and mercy,
we tend to make things so complicated,
creating elaborate belief systems,
while neglecting what matters most.
When we are overwhelmed by
the world's problems, help us return to the fundamentals:
doing justice,
loving mercy,
walking humbly within your Mystery.

Give us courage to choose compassion
when our dominant culture deems empathy as weakness.
Help us recognize practical ways to embody your justice
when tasks overwhelm and seem too large.
Make us people who reflect your heart so clearly
that others experience your inclusive love through us.

-[BenjaminCremer/adapt. ML]

May it ever be so.

May it ever be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Without You, Without Them"
Tiffany Ho, Laurel Irene, and Molly Pease

JULIEN BAKER, PHOEBE BRIDGERS,
AND LUCY DACUS

Sermon

Justice, Mercy, Humility

Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Schiefelbein

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"More Than Enough"
Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, Soloist

SUSAN LABARR

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Offering Prayer

Rev. Schiefelbein

Holy God, as we bring our offerings to you,
we remember those who are vulnerable to suffering and injustice.
Make us people who are gracious in our giving, tender in our mercy and care,
and fierce in our protection of all your beloved people.

May it ever be so.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

May God bless us with the courage to face discomfort,
that we may grow in compassion for those who suffer.

*May God bless us with restlessness,
so that we are not content with the injustices of this world.*

May God bless us with humble hearts,
to sense and know the Sacred in ourselves and in all.

*May God bless us with deep and unwavering peace,
that it might hold us in the chaos and the quiet alike.*

And may we always remember,
that in the discomfort, and the struggle...
God is present, ever guiding us toward love.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Bawo Thixo Somandla" MXOLISI MATYILA; arr. SIDUMO NYAMEZELE
Laude

*"Dear God, show us our wrongdoings that have led to these conflicts
so that we may move in the ways of humility."*

*Hymn for the Journey

Creative Love

TALLIS' CANON

Creative love, our thanks we give
That this our world, is incomplete,
That struggle greets our will to live,
That work awaits our hands and feet.

That we are not yet fully wise,
That we are in the making still -
As friends who share one enterprise
And strive to blend with nature's will.

What though the future long delay,
And still with faults we daily cope?
It gives us that for which we pray,
A field for toil and faith and hope.

Since what we choose is what we are,
And what we love we yet shall be,
The goal may ever shine afar -
The will to reach it makes us free.

-lyrics by W.W. Hyde

Postlude

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, Guest Organist
Recessional, William Mathias (1934-1992)

Inside The Music

"I've spent a lot of time meditating on justice recently. My reflections have been somewhat fraught. Like with most societally-dependent concepts, I keep coming back to people and relationships. I think that's why the Micah text for this week feels important to me. Justice, mercy, and humility are interwoven into a clear sign that points to the possibility for healthy communities. The music this week grows from this text. Jaebon's "Arise, Shine" introit is a favorite of mine, and I'm excited to get to sing it with her. I have always appreciated the harmonic worlds she inhabits in such a short amount of time. All twelve notes of the chromatic scale are well represented. There are three distinct tonal areas, and the main D tonal area has a persistent duality. To my ear this all speaks to a universality. The light that has come is for all of us and is everywhere around us to be received. Boy Genius' "Without You, Without Them" is a relatively new piece in the a cappella vocal band genre. I am drawn to its lyrical simplicity and lilting melodiousness. These inviting elements set us up to embrace the most important practice of opening to others. They ask us to sit with each other and listen, to be in relationship. Susan LaBarr's setting of Wendell Berry's poem coaxes us into an abundance mindset. Her pastoral setting punctuated by moments of rhythmic and chromatic excitement illuminates the heart of Berry's profound words. Surely the essence of humility lies in realizing that we are sufficient as we are, in this moment. The South African protest anthem "Bawo Thixo Somandla" ends our morning. It is yearning as it is powerful, and asks the question of why we persist in hurting one another. Compassion's desire that all people be given the opportunity to avoid suffering sits at the heart of justice. For some reason humanity continues to

struggle to understand this. Music continues to bring us back to shared experiences where we may learn lessons of togetherness in small, important doses.” ~ Dr. David Harris

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